



AN INSIDER'S CHECKLIST

The 12 Reasons Canadian Employers Skip Your Resume

— *and how to fix each one.*

*An insider's checklist from someone who has reviewed the resumes
and sat in the hiring room.*

12

FIXABLE REASONS

~10

MINUTE READ

Both

SIDES OF THE TABLE

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CAREER GUIDANCE FOR NEWCOMERS IN CANADA

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BEFORE YOU START

If you're applying and hearing almost nothing back, I want to tell you what I wish someone had told me when I first arrived in Canada: **this is very rarely about your ability.**

I've reviewed countless resumes from the hiring side of the table, and watched genuinely capable people — engineers, accountants, managers, specialists — get passed over for a handful of fixable things they had no way of knowing. Here are the twelve I see most often.

WHAT THIS CHECKLIST GIVES YOU

- ✓ Understand why you're hearing nothing back — in plain language.
- ✓ Twelve specific, fixable issues, from the person who reads your resume.
- ✓ A clear, low-pressure place to start today.

HOW TO USE IT

- 1 Skim all twelve first — don't fix anything yet.
- 2 Tick the boxes that sound like your resume.
- 3 Fix the two or three that sting the most, first.



QUICK WIN — READ THIS FIRST

You don't need to fix all twelve. Skim the list, tick the two or three that make you wince, and start there. For most people, **three or four changes** are enough to shift the response they get.



Make it unmistakably Canadian

First impressions are formatting. These are the quiet signals that say 'new here' — and the fastest wins on the list.

☐ 1 There's no clear 'who I am' in the first five seconds.

Why it costs you: If I can't tell what you do and what you're aiming for at a glance, on a busy day I move on.

✓ THE FIX

Put your name and a clean contact line at the very top, then a 2–3 line summary: who you are, your strongest skill, and the exact role you want.

☐ 2 Your resume still reads like it was built for another country.

Why it costs you: Photos, age, marital status, or a full home address are normal in many places — here, they can quietly get a resume set aside.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE

Adding a photo to feel more personal. In Canada it backfires — many employers screen out or strip photos to avoid any appearance of bias, so it can only cost you the read.

✓ THE FIX

No photo, no age, no marital status. City and province is plenty. Keep it to one or two pages, most recent first.

🔗 PRO TIP

Two pages is the ceiling, even with decades behind you. List older roles by title and years; 'further detail available on request' is a perfectly Canadian line, and it keeps the page clean.

☐ 3 It's a wall of text, so the best parts get missed.

Why it costs you: The first pass is seconds, not minutes — dense blocks hide exactly what you want me to see.

✓ THE FIX

Short bullet points, clear headings, real white space. Lead each bullet with the words that matter most. Skimmable in ten seconds, readable in two minutes.

☐ 4 Small details are quietly undermining you.

Why it costs you: An unprofessional email, a typo, mismatched dates, a missing LinkedIn — none sinks you alone, but together they whisper ‘careless.’

✓ THE FIX

Use a simple professional email (firstname.lastname@...). Proofread twice, then have someone else check. Keep formatting consistent and add a clean LinkedIn URL.



PART 2 OF 4

Get past the filters

Before a person ever reads you, software and a ten-second scan decide if you make the pile. Here's how to clear both.

☐ 5 It's the same resume you send everywhere.

Why it costs you: I can spot a mass-sent resume in seconds — and so can the software. It signals you're applying to everything, not to this.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE

Firing off 200 applications and waiting. Volume feels like progress, but it isn't. Ten tailored applications beat a hundred generic ones — every single time.

✓ THE FIX

Tailor the top third to each posting. Mirror the exact words it uses for skills and responsibilities — as long as they're true for you. Retarget what I read first.

☐ 6 The software filters you out before a human sees you.

Why it costs you: Most mid-to-large employers use a system that scans for the posting's keywords. Say ‘client relations’ when it says ‘stakeholder management’ and you vanish.

✓ THE FIX

Use the posting's exact wording for skills and tools (truthfully). Avoid tables, text boxes, headers/footers and images — many systems can't read them. Clean layout is what gets parsed.



Translate your story

Your experience is real. The job is making it legible to someone who's never seen your country's companies, titles, or credentials.

☐ 7 Your experience is impressive, but it doesn't translate.

Why it costs you: If I've never heard of your employer, that prestige is invisible to me — and titles that don't map to Canadian ones leave me unable to size your experience.

✓ THE FIX

Add a short line of context to each unfamiliar employer — industry, size, what it does. Translate your title to its closest Canadian equivalent. Give me a frame of reference.

Q PRO TIP

Coming from India or elsewhere with big local names? Don't assume they travel. One line — 'one of the largest private banks in the country, 12,000 employees' — turns an unknown into an asset.

☐ 8 Your credentials are strong but unexplained.

Why it costs you: A foreign degree on its own often means little to someone who doesn't know how it compares — and that uncertainty becomes a reason to move on.

✓ THE FIX

Present your education clearly and with confidence. Where you can, note a Canadian equivalency right on the resume.

Q PRO TIP

Get your credentials assessed — WES is the common route — and put the equivalency on the page. It isn't required, but I'd encourage every newcomer to do it: it removes the guesswork for the person reading you.

☐ 9 Your most relevant experience is buried.

Why it costs you: Survival jobs at the top — completely understandable — while your real expertise hides below makes the resume read as a step down.

✓ THE FIX

Lead with your most relevant and senior experience. Group or briefly note recent stopgap roles without letting them dominate. The first thing I see should be the strongest thing you've done.

☐ 10 Unexplained gaps are creating doubt.

Why it costs you: A gap isn't automatically a problem — but an unexplained one invites questions you're not in the room to answer.

✓ THE FIX

Account for meaningful gaps in one honest line — relocation, the immigration process, upskilling, caregiving. You don't owe a detailed story; you just close the loop.

🔗 PRO TIP

Relocating or going through the immigration process is not a weakness — name it plainly in one line. Silence invites worse assumptions than the truth ever would.



PART 4 OF 4

Make your value impossible to miss

Same career, told two ways: a list of duties, or a record of impact. Only one gets the call.

☐ 11 You listed your duties instead of your impact.

Why it costs you: 'Responsible for managing projects and budgets' tells me your title — not whether you were any good. Without numbers, I have nothing concrete to weigh.

✓ THE FIX

Turn each bullet into a result. Add numbers, percentages, dollars, timeframes, scale. 'Managed budgets' becomes 'managed a \$2.4M budget with zero overruns across three years.' Same work — finally visible.

☐ 12 It reads as a list of tasks, not contributions to a team.

Why it costs you: Canadian workplaces prize collaboration and business impact. A pure list of technical tasks can read as a fit risk, even when the skills are clearly there.

✓ THE FIX

Frame achievements as outcomes and teamwork: who you worked with, what changed because of you, what the business gained. Show the person behind the skills.



IF YOU REMEMBER ONE THING

This is almost never about your ability. It's about how clearly your value comes across on the page — and **that gap is completely fixable.**

ONE LAST THING, FROM ME

You're more qualified than this page makes you look.

After years on the hiring side, the thing I most want you to hear is that capable, deserving people get passed over every day — for reasons that have nothing to do with their ability. You've just taken the first real step toward closing that gap.

Want an insider read on your own resume?

I take on a small group of people at a reduced rate while I build my practice — a personal, honest look at the specific things quietly costing you interviews.

→ **Apply or book a free intro call**

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Employment & hiring guidance — not immigration advice.

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